Ask Dad First

Fifteen questions for him, for the family, and the few that belong to his doctor or pharmacist, with room to write what each one says.

Your sister is sure Dad can't have shellfish. Dad says he just never liked it. One of those is a question for him, and one may be a question for his doctor.

This guide sorts the questions by who can answer them. It doesn't answer any of them and doesn't say which matters most. Write what each person says under the question, with the date.

Dad

Most of this page is his to answer, and none of it has a deadline. Two or three questions over a meal is plenty; the rest will keep.

1. What makes an ordinary day a good one for you?

2. How do you like your mornings to go, and how do you like to wind down in the evening?

3. What do you enjoy eating, what would you rather not be served, and when do you like your meals?

4. Is there anything you leave alone because of an allergy or because a doctor told you to, and not simply because you don't care for it?

5. Who and what do you look forward to in a week?

6. What would you want someone to understand about you if they were ever helping you out?

7. Which of this are you happy for the family to share, and with whom?

8. How should we keep this current? When would you like to be asked again?

The rest of the family

Anyone who knows a part of Dad's week. Ask each person on their own if you can, and ask how they know.

1. What do you believe Dad likes and dislikes day to day? Did he tell you, or is it something you've gathered over the years?

2. When did you last hear that from him?

3. Is there anything you think Dad can't eat or drink? Where did you hear it?

His doctor or pharmacist

For Dad to ask at a regular visit, or for you to ask with him there if he'd like the company. What they say goes on a separate list from his likes and dislikes, in their words.

1. Which allergies, if any, are on Dad's record with you?

2. Has he been given any instruction about food or drink that he should be following now?

3. Can he have that in writing, with a date?

Your care consultant

Someone who looks at what you've written alongside the rest of Dad's situation.

1. When might a page like this be worth sharing, and with whom?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions or say which one matters most. Where Dad's answer and a relative's differ, write down both. This page doesn't pick between them, and it doesn't turn anything Dad likes into an instruction.

Ready for the next step?

You know which questions are Dad's, which are the family's and which belong to a clinician, and you have room for what each one says. The care interview gives those answers somewhere to go: it walks through Dad's situation area by area, notes where his account and the family's differ, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The first question follows the good-day question in The Conversation Project's workbook. The other questions and the grouping by role are ours.

1. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement) and Ariadne Labs, What Matters to Me: A Workbook for Better Health Care